

Jeremiah 37 - 39

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight the thing Jeremiah has been announcing for forty years finally happens.

A siege lifted for a few weeks, and a nation that read the reprieve as a rescue.

A prophet arrested at a city gate on a charge of desertion while walking to claim a field.

A cistern with no water in it, only mud, and a man sinking into it in the dark.

A wall breached on the ninth day of the fourth month, and a king caught running.

Jeremiah 37 shows a king who wants prayer without obedience and a prophet who tells him the truth twice - once publicly, once in a private room - and is jailed for it both times.

Jeremiah 38 puts Jeremiah at the bottom of a pit and then sends the least likely rescuer in the book: a foreign eunuch who noticed.

Jeremiah 39 records the fall itself in the flattest prose imaginable, and then spends its last four verses on one man who trusted Yahweh and was told so by name.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 37 - The Reprieve That Was Not a Rescue

Key Notes

- Zedekiah is introduced as a Babylonian appointee, installed in place of Coniah - a king whose throne exists by permission of the empire he will rebel against (Jeremiah 37:1).
- Verse 2 is the epitaph on the reign: neither the king, nor his servants, nor the people of the land listened to Yahweh's words spoken through Jeremiah (Jeremiah 37:2).
- Zedekiah sends for prayer again, exactly as in chapter 21. He wants intercession without instruction - the request is for an outcome, not for a word (Jeremiah 37:3).
- Pharaoh's army marches out, the Chaldeans break camp, and Jerusalem exhales. The whole chapter turns on how a city reads a temporary lull (Jeremiah 37:5).
- Yahweh's answer is immediate and unwelcome: Egypt goes home, Babylon returns, and the city burns. The reprieve changes nothing about the ending (Jeremiah 37:7-8).
- "Don't deceive yourselves" is the pastoral center of the chapter. The danger is not the enemy outside but the story being told inside the walls (Jeremiah 37:9).
- The hyperbole in verse 10 is deliberate: even an army of wounded men left in their tents would be enough, because the outcome does not depend on the strength of the instrument (Jeremiah 37:10).
- Jeremiah leaves during the lull to claim his portion in Benjamin - almost certainly the Anathoth field he bought in chapter 32 - and is arrested at the gate (Jeremiah 37:11-13).
- The charge is desertion, and it is false, and Jeremiah says so plainly: "That is false! I am not defecting to the Chaldeans." He is not believed (Jeremiah 37:14).
- He is beaten and put in a converted house - the scribe Jonathan's home turned into a prison - in a dungeon with cells, where he stays many days (Jeremiah 37:15-16).
- Zedekiah summons him secretly and asks the question he cannot stop asking: "Is there any word from Yahweh?" The answer is two words long and unchanged (Jeremiah 37:17).
- Jeremiah then does something remarkable: he asks a fair question of his own. Where are the prophets who told you Babylon would never come? (Jeremiah 37:18-19).
- His only request is not to be sent back to Jonathan's house, and the king grants it. Jeremiah is moved to the court of the guard and given a daily loaf until the bread runs out (Jeremiah 37:20-21).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
A Reign That Would Not Listen	Jeremiah 37:2 • Jeremiah 25:3-4 • 2 Chronicles 36:12-13
Prayer Requested Without Obedience	Jeremiah 37:3 • Jeremiah 21:1-2 • Jeremiah 42:2
Leaning on Egypt	Jeremiah 37:5 • Ezekiel 17:15 • Isaiah 31:1

Topic	References
"Don't Deceive Yourselves"	Jeremiah 37:9 • Jeremiah 29:8 • Galatians 6:3
Arrested on a False Charge	Jeremiah 37:13-14 • Jeremiah 38:4 • Amos 7:10
The Messenger Beaten and Jailed	Jeremiah 37:15 • Acts 16:22-23 • 2 Corinthians 11:23-25
A King Who Asks in Secret	Jeremiah 37:17 • Jeremiah 38:14-16 • 1 Kings 22:16
"Where Are Your Prophets Now?"	Jeremiah 37:19 • Jeremiah 28:2-4 • Jeremiah 14:13

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Accused Falsely and Not Believed	Jeremiah 37:14 • Matthew 26:59-61 • John 18:30
Coming to Him by Night	Jeremiah 37:17 • John 3:2 • John 19:38
The Same Word Under Pressure	Jeremiah 37:17 • John 18:20 • 2 Timothy 2:9
Supplication Presented Before the Throne	Jeremiah 37:20 • Philippians 4:6 • Hebrews 5:7
Daily Bread in a Starving City	Jeremiah 37:21 • Matthew 6:11 • Philippians 4:19
Kept Alive Until the Appointed Day	Jeremiah 37:21 • Jeremiah 15:20 • John 7:30

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 37 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the Egyptian reprieve, the arrest at Benjamin's gate, and the secret interview with Zedekiah
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 37](#) - the final years of Zedekiah's reign set in their historical and covenant context
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 37](#) - exposition of self-deception during a temporary reprieve

Jeremiah 37 - Opening Intro

The most dangerous thing that happens in this chapter is good news.

Pharaoh Hophra marches out of Egypt, the Babylonians pull back from Jerusalem to deal with him, and for the first time in months there is no army outside the wall. People go out to the fields. The markets reopen. And the entire city draws the wrong conclusion.

Yahweh's response is almost unbearably direct. Egypt is going home. Babylon is coming back. And then verse 9: "Don't deceive yourselves." The Hebrew is literally *do not lift up your own souls* - do not tell yourselves a story that makes you feel better than the facts warrant.

Notice that Jeremiah himself uses the lull to go collect his property in Benjamin, which is almost certainly the Anathoth field from chapter 32. He believed his own prophecy about eventual restoration enough to go act on the deed. And that is what gets him arrested - a man walking north toward Chaldean-held territory looks exactly like a defector.

The charge is false and he says so, and it makes no difference. There is a particular loneliness in being punished for something you did not do while being right about everything you did say, and Jeremiah lives in it for many days in a converted house with cells in the basement.

Then Zedekiah sends for him privately. "Is there any word from Yahweh?" And this is the measure of Jeremiah: he has every incentive to soften it. He is in a dungeon. The man asking controls whether he goes back. His answer is two words in Hebrew - *yesh*, there is - and then the same sentence he has been saying for years.

Before we read, weigh the difference between the king's question and the king's intention. Zedekiah asks for the word repeatedly across these chapters and never once obeys it. It is possible to be genuinely curious about what God says and never let it cost you anything.

Jeremiah 37:1-21 (WEB)

1 Zedekiah the son of Josiah reigned as king, instead of Coniah the son of Jehoiakim, whom Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon made king in the land of Judah.

2 But neither he, nor his servants, nor the people of the land, listened to Yahweh's words, which he spoke by the prophet Jeremiah.¹

3 Zedekiah the king sent Jehucal the son of Shelemiah, and Zephaniah the son of Maaseiah, the priest, to the prophet Jeremiah, saying, "Pray now to Yahweh our God for us."²

4 Now Jeremiah came in and went out among the people; for they had not put him into prison.

5 Pharaoh's army had come out of Egypt; and when the Chaldeans who were besieging Jerusalem heard news of them, they broke up from Jerusalem.³

6 Then Yahweh's word came to the prophet Jeremiah, saying,

7 "Yahweh, the God of Israel, says, 'You shall tell the king of Judah, who sent you to me to inquire of me: "Behold, Pharaoh's army, which has come out to help you, will return to Egypt into their own land.

8 The Chaldeans will come again, and fight against this city. They will take it and burn it with fire.'"

¹ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 25:3-4](#) • [2 Chronicles 36:12-13](#) - the charge that outlives every reign - Yahweh spoke and they did not listen

² Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 21:1-2](#) • [Jeremiah 42:2](#) - the same delegation language twice more in this book - prayer requested, counsel refused

³ Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 17:15](#) • [Isaiah 31:1](#) - the rebellion that leaned on Pharaoh, and woe to those who go down to Egypt for help

9 “Yahweh says, ‘Don’t deceive yourselves, saying, “The Chaldeans will surely depart from us;” for they will not depart.’⁴

10 For though you had struck the whole army of the Chaldeans who fight against you, and there remained but wounded men among them, yes they would each rise up in his tent and burn this city with fire.’”

11 When the army of the Chaldeans had broken up from Jerusalem for fear of Pharaoh’s army,

12 then Jeremiah went out of Jerusalem to go into the land of Benjamin, to receive his portion there, in the middle of the people.

13 When he was in Benjamin’s gate, a captain of the guard was there, whose name was Irijah, the son of Shelemiah, the son of Hananiah; and he seized Jeremiah the prophet, saying, “You are defecting to the Chaldeans!”⁵

14 Then Jeremiah said, “That is false! I am not defecting to the Chaldeans.” But he didn’t listen to him; so Irijah siezed Jeremiah, and brought him to the princes.

15 The princes were angry with Jeremiah, and struck him, and put him in prison in the house of Jonathan the scribe; for they had made that the prison.⁶

16 When Jeremiah had come into the dungeon house, and into the cells, and Jeremiah had remained there many days,

17 then Zedekiah the king sent, and had him brought out. The king asked him secretly in his house, “Is there any word from Yahweh?” Jeremiah said, “There is.” He also said, “You will be delivered into the hand of the king of Babylon.”^{7,8}

18 Moreover Jeremiah said to king Zedekiah, “How have I sinned against you, against your servants, or against this people, that you have put me in prison?

19 Now where are your prophets who prophesied to you, saying, ‘The king of Babylon will not come against you, nor against this land?’⁹

⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 29:8](#) • [Galatians 6:3](#) - deception that originates inside - dreams you cause to be dreamed, thinking yourself something

⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 26:59-61](#) • [John 18:30](#) - false testimony sought against the Righteous One, and an accusation offered without evidence

⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Acts 16:22-23](#) • [2 Corinthians 11:23-25](#) - beaten and thrown into prison - the standing cost of carrying an unwelcome word

⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 38:14-16](#) • [1 Kings 22:16](#) - a king demanding the truth privately while refusing it publicly

⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [John 3:2](#) • [John 19:38](#) - Nicodemus coming by night, and Joseph a disciple secretly for fear

⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 28:2-4](#) • [Jeremiah 14:13](#) - the comfortable prophecies of Hananiah and the peace-preachers, now conspicuously absent

20 Now please hear, my lord the king: please let my supplication be presented before you, that you not cause me to return to the house of Jonathan the scribe, lest I die there.”¹⁰

21 Then Zedekiah the king commanded, and they committed Jeremiah into the court of the guard. They gave him daily a loaf of bread out of the bakers’ street, until all the bread in the city was gone. Thus Jeremiah remained in the court of the guard.^{11,12}

¹⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [Philippians 4:6](#) • [Hebrews 5:7](#) - supplication made with thanksgiving, and prayers offered up with strong crying

¹¹ **Cross-Reference:** [1 Kings 17:6](#) • [Psalm 37:25](#) - bread brought daily in famine, and the righteous not forsaken

¹² **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 6:11](#) • [Philippians 4:19](#) - give us today our daily bread, and God supplying every need according to His riches

CHAPTER 38 - The Cistern, the Rags, and the King Who Could Not Decide

Key Notes

- Four officials are named - Shephatiah, Gedaliah, Jucal, Pashhur - which matters, because a bulla bearing the name Jehucal son of Shelemiah was excavated in Jerusalem in 2005 (Jeremiah 38:1).
- The message they object to is the surrender offer from chapter 21, unchanged: stay and die, go out and live (Jeremiah 38:2-3).
- The charge against Jeremiah is demoralization - "he weakens the hands of the men of war" - and in strictly military terms it is accurate. Truth was bad for morale (Jeremiah 38:4).
- Zedekiah's reply is one of the most pathetic sentences a king ever spoke: "he is in your hand; for the king can't do anything to oppose you" (Jeremiah 38:5).
- They lower him into a cistern belonging to the king's son - no water, only mud - and Jeremiah sinks. The detail that there was no water is the detail that means he will die slowly (Jeremiah 38:6).
- The rescuer is Ebedmelech: a foreigner, an Ethiopian, a eunuch, a palace servant - a man with no standing under the law and no political base whatsoever (Jeremiah 38:7).
- He goes to the king in public, at Benjamin's gate, and calls the act what it is: "these men have done evil in all that they have done to Jeremiah" (Jeremiah 38:8-9).
- Zedekiah reverses himself instantly and grants thirty men. The same king who could not oppose the princes an hour ago can suddenly act when one honest person asks (Jeremiah 38:10).
- The rags are the most tender detail in the book. Ebedmelech goes to the treasury for worn-out clothes so the ropes will not cut Jeremiah's armpits on the way up (Jeremiah 38:11-12).
- The king then holds a second secret interview and swears an oath - and Jeremiah's opening reply shows he has stopped expecting anything: "If I give you counsel, you will not listen to me" (Jeremiah 38:14-15).
- The offer is repeated one final time, personally and simply: go out, and you live, and the city is not burned, and your household survives (Jeremiah 38:17).
- Zedekiah names his real reason for refusing, and it is not theology or strategy. He is afraid of being mocked by the Judeans who already defected (Jeremiah 38:19).
- The chapter ends with the king coaching Jeremiah on what to tell the princes - managing his image to the last - and Jeremiah remaining in the guard court until the city falls (Jeremiah 38:24-28).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Surrender Offer Repeated	Jeremiah 38:2 • Jeremiah 21:8-9 • Jeremiah 27:12
"He Weakens the Hands of the Men of War"	Jeremiah 38:4 • Amos 7:10 • Acts 16:20-21

Topic	References
A King Overruled by His Own Officials	Jeremiah 38:5 • Proverbs 29:25 • 1 Samuel 15:24
Sunk in the Miry Pit	Jeremiah 38:6 • Psalm 40:2 • Lamentations 3:53-55
An Ethiopian Eunuch in the King's House	Jeremiah 38:7 • Acts 8:27 • Isaiah 56:3-5
Speaking for One Who Cannot Speak	Jeremiah 38:9 • Proverbs 31:8-9 • James 1:27
Truth Told to a Man Who May Kill You	Jeremiah 38:15 • Jeremiah 26:14-15 • Amos 5:10
Familiar Friends Who Prevail	Jeremiah 38:22 • Psalm 41:9 • Obadiah 1:7

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
"He Stirs Up the People"	Jeremiah 38:4 • Luke 23:2 • John 11:48
Out of the Deep Mire Where There Is No Standing	Jeremiah 38:6 • Psalm 69:1-2 • Psalm 69:14-15
Kindness in the Mechanics of Rescue	Jeremiah 38:12 • Matthew 25:40 • Colossians 3:12
Surrender as the Way to Live	Jeremiah 38:17 • Jeremiah 21:9 • Matthew 16:25
Fearing the Opinion of Men	Jeremiah 38:19 • John 12:42-43 • Galatians 1:10
The Outsider Who Did the Right Thing	Jeremiah 38:7-13 • Luke 10:33 • Matthew 8:10

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 38 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the cistern, Ebedmelech's intervention, and Zedekiah's final refusal
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 38](#) - the surrender offer read as covenant mercy rather than political capitulation
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 38](#) - exposition of Zedekiah's fear of man as the decisive factor in Jerusalem's fall

Jeremiah 38 - Opening Intro

There are two men in this chapter who could have saved Jerusalem, and neither one is Jeremiah.

The first is the king. Zedekiah has the authority, he has the prophet, he has the offer in writing, and he has been told three separate times exactly what to do. In verse 5 he hands Jeremiah to men who want him dead with a sentence that should be carved on the tomb of every leader who ever knew better and folded: "he is in your hand; for the king can't do anything to oppose you." He can. He simply will not.

The second is Ebedmelech, and everything about him is wrong for the role. He is Ethiopian, so a foreigner. He is a eunuch, which under Deuteronomy 23 barred him from the assembly. He is a servant in the palace, not a prince. He has no vote, no army, and no legal standing. And he is the only person in Jerusalem who does anything.

Look at what his intervention actually costs him. He walks out to Benjamin's gate where the king is sitting in public session, and he says out loud that the princes have done evil. That is a career-ending sentence in a city where those princes just demonstrated they can override the throne.

Then comes verse 11, which is the detail I cannot get past. He does not just get a rope. He goes into the treasury and finds old rags and worn-out clothes, lowers them down first, and tells Jeremiah to pad his armpits so the cords will not tear his skin. The man has been in a sewage pit for who knows how long and is about to be hauled out by thirty men, and Ebedmelech is thinking about rope burn.

That is what it looks like when someone actually sees a person. Not the cause - the person.

The chapter's tragedy is that Zedekiah gets one more chance after that, a private one, under oath, with the offer reduced to its simplest form: go out and live. And he says no, and gives the reason: he is afraid the defectors will laugh at him. A city burns because a king could not bear to be mocked.

Before we read, sit with the two questions this chapter puts to us. Which of those men are we - the one with authority who will not use it, or the one with no standing who acts anyway? And what are we currently refusing to do because of who might find out?

Jeremiah 38:1-28 (WEB)

1 Shephatiah the son of Mattan, and Gedaliah the son of Pashhur, and Jucal the son of Shelemiah, and Pashhur the son of Malchijah, heard the words that Jeremiah spoke to all the people, saying,

2 "Yahweh says, 'He who remains in this city will die by the sword, by the famine, and by the pestilence; but he who goes out to the Chaldeans will live, and he will escape with his life, and he will live.'¹³

3 Yahweh says, 'This city will surely be given into the hand of the army of the king of Babylon, and he will take it.'"

4 Then the princes said to the king, "Please let this man be put to death; because he weakens the hands of the men of war who remain in this city, and the hands of all the people, in speaking such words to them: for this man doesn't seek the welfare of this people, but harm."^{14,15}

5 Zedekiah the king said, "Behold, he is in your hand; for the king can't do anything to oppose you."

¹³ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 21:8-9](#) • [Jeremiah 27:12](#) - the same offer given to the city and to the king - bring your neck under, and live

¹⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Amos 7:10](#) • [Acts 16:20-21](#) - the prophet charged with conspiracy, and messengers accused of troubling the city

¹⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Luke 23:2](#) • [John 11:48](#) - he stirs up the people, and if we let him go the Romans will come and take our place

6 Then took they Jeremiah and threw him into the dungeon of Malchijah the king's son, that was in the court of the guard. They let down Jeremiah with cords. In the dungeon there was no water, but mire; and Jeremiah sank in the mire.^{16,17}

7 Now when Ebedmelech the Ethiopian, a eunuch, who was in the king's house, heard that they had put Jeremiah in the dungeon (the king was then sitting in Benjamin's gate),¹⁸

8 Ebedmelech went out of the king's house, and spoke to the king, saying,

9 "My lord the king, these men have done evil in all that they have done to Jeremiah the prophet, whom they have cast into the dungeon. He is likely to die in the place where he is, because of the famine; for there is no more bread in the city."¹⁹

10 Then the king commanded Ebedmelech the Ethiopian, saying, "Take from here thirty men with you, and take up Jeremiah the prophet out of the dungeon, before he dies."

11 So Ebedmelech took the men with him, and went into the house of the king under the treasury, and took from there rags and worn-out garments, and let them down by cords into the dungeon to Jeremiah.

12 Ebedmelech the Ethiopian said to Jeremiah, "Now put these rags and worn-out garments under your armpits under the cords." Jeremiah did so.²⁰

13 So they drew up Jeremiah with the cords, and took him up out of the dungeon; and Jeremiah remained in the court of the guard.

14 Then Zedekiah the king sent and took Jeremiah the prophet to himself into the third entry that is in Yahweh's house. Then the king said to Jeremiah, "I will ask you something. Hide nothing from me."

15 Then Jeremiah said to Zedekiah, "If I declare it to you, will you not surely put me to death? If I give you counsel, you will not listen to me."²¹

16 So Zedekiah the king swore secretly to Jeremiah, saying, "As Yahweh lives, who made us this soul, I will not put you to death, neither will I give you into the hand of these men who seek your life."

¹⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 40:2](#) • [Lamentations 3:53-55](#) - brought up out of a horrible pit and the miry clay, and a voice calling from the lowest dungeon

¹⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [Psalm 69:1-2](#) • [Psalm 69:14-15](#) - sunk in deep mire where there is no standing - a psalm the Gospels apply to Messiah

¹⁸ **Cross-Reference:** [Acts 8:27](#) • [Isaiah 56:3-5](#) - another Ethiopian official who feared God, and eunuchs promised a name better than sons

¹⁹ **Messianic Connection:** [Proverbs 31:8-9](#) • [James 1:27](#) - opening your mouth for the one who cannot speak, and religion measured by whom you visit

²⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 25:40](#) • [Colossians 3:12](#) - done to the least of these, and a heart of compassion shown in the smallest mechanics

²¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 26:14-15](#) • [Amos 5:10](#) - the prophet who tells the truth knowing it may cost him, to men who hate the one who reproves

17 Then Jeremiah said to Zedekiah, “Yahweh, the God of Armies, the God of Israel, says: ‘If you will go out to the king of Babylon’s princes, then your soul will live, and this city will not be burned with fire. You will live, along with your house.’”²²

18 But if you will not go out to the king of Babylon’s princes, then this city will be given into the hand of the Chaldeans, and they will burn it with fire, and you won’t escape out of their hand.’”

19 Zedekiah the king said to Jeremiah, “I am afraid of the Jews who have defected to the Chaldeans, lest they deliver me into their hand, and they mock me.”²³

20 But Jeremiah said, “They won’t deliver you. Obey, I beg you, Yahweh’s voice, in that which I speak to you; so it will be well with you, and your soul will live.

21 But if you refuse to go out, this is the word that Yahweh has shown me:

22 ‘Behold, all the women who are left in the king of Judah’s house will be brought out to the king of Babylon’s princes, and those women will say, “Your familiar friends have turned on you, and have prevailed over you. Your feet are sunk in the mire, they have turned away from you.”’²⁴

23 They will bring out all your wives and your children to the Chaldeans. You won’t escape out of their hand, but will be taken by the hand of the king of Babylon. You will cause this city to be burned with fire.’”

24 Then Zedekiah said to Jeremiah, “Let no man know of these words, and you won’t die.

25 But if the princes hear that I have talked with you, and they come to you, and tell you, ‘Declare to us now what you have said to the king; don’t hide it from us, and we will not put you to death; also tell us what the king said to you;’

26 then you shall tell them, ‘I presented my supplication before the king, that he would not cause me to return to Jonathan’s house, to die there.’”

27 Then all the princes came to Jeremiah, and asked him; and he told them according to all these words that the king had commanded. So they stopped speaking with him; for the matter was not perceived.

28 So Jeremiah stayed in the court of the guard until the day that Jerusalem was taken.”²⁵

²² **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 21:9](#) • [2 Kings 24:12](#) - surrender offered as life, and Jehoiachin who went out and lived to eat at a king’s table

²³ **Messianic Connection:** [John 12:42-43](#) • [Galatians 1:10](#) - loving the praise of men more than the praise of God - the fear that decided this war

²⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 41:9](#) • [Obadiah 1:7](#) - trusted friends who turn, and the men at peace with you who set a trap

²⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 39:14](#) • [Jeremiah 15:20](#) - preserved through the fall, exactly as promised at his recommissioning

CHAPTER 39 - The Day the Wall Was Breached

Key Notes

- The chapter opens with a date, not a lament. Ninth year, tenth month for the siege; eleventh year, fourth month, ninth day for the breach - about eighteen months of starvation between them (Jeremiah 39:1-2).
- Babylonian officers sit in the middle gate, which was the seat of civic authority. The occupation is announced by where the officials sit rather than by any declaration (Jeremiah 39:3).
- Zedekiah runs at night through the gate between the two walls, by the king's garden - the same man who was afraid of being mocked, now fleeing in the dark (Jeremiah 39:4).
- He is caught in the plains of Jericho and brought to Riblah, where Nebuchadnezzar passes sentence. The prophecy that he would speak with the king of Babylon mouth to mouth is fulfilled literally (Jeremiah 39:5).
- His sons are killed in front of him, and then his eyes are put out - so that the last thing he ever saw was the thing he most wanted not to see (Jeremiah 39:6-7).
- The two prophecies that appeared to contradict are both fulfilled exactly: he saw the king of Babylon's eyes, and he never saw Babylon (Jeremiah 39:7).
- The city, the palace, and the houses are burned and the walls broken down. Four verses cover what forty chapters warned about (Jeremiah 39:8).
- In one of the strangest reversals in Scripture, the poorest people - those who owned nothing - are left in the land and given vineyards and fields (Jeremiah 39:10).
- Nebuchadnezzar personally issues orders about Jeremiah: take him, look after him, do him no harm, and do whatever he tells you (Jeremiah 39:11-12).
- The man whose own countrymen jailed, beat, and dropped in a cistern is protected by the empire he was accused of siding with (Jeremiah 39:13-14).
- Jeremiah is handed to Gedaliah son of Ahikam - the son of the man who saved his life in chapter 26. Two generations of one family keep this prophet alive (Jeremiah 39:14).
- The chapter's last word is not about the city at all. It is a personal oracle for Ebedmelech, delivered before the fall, promising him his life "because you have put your trust in me" (Jeremiah 39:15-18).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Breach in the Wall	Jeremiah 39:2 • 2 Kings 25:3-4 • Ezekiel 33:21
The King Who Fled by Night	Jeremiah 39:4 • Jeremiah 38:18 • Amos 2:14-16
Seeing the King of Babylon's Eyes	Jeremiah 39:6 • Jeremiah 34:3 • Ezekiel 12:13
Blinded and Carried to Babylon	Jeremiah 39:7 • 2 Kings 25:7 • Jeremiah 32:4

Topic	References
The House and the City Burned	Jeremiah 39:8 • Jeremiah 7:14 • Micah 3:12
The Poor Given Vineyards and Fields	Jeremiah 39:10 • Jeremiah 40:7 • Matthew 5:5
An Enemy Made to Deal Kindly	Jeremiah 39:12 • Jeremiah 15:11 • Proverbs 16:7
Committed to the House of Shaphan Again	Jeremiah 39:14 • Jeremiah 38:28 • Jeremiah 26:24

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Lowly Lifted and the Poor Enriched	Jeremiah 39:10 • Luke 1:52-53 • James 2:5
Kept by a Hand Outside the Covenant	Jeremiah 39:11-12 • Ezra 1:1 • Proverbs 21:1
Deliverance Promised Before the Disaster	Jeremiah 39:16-17 • Jeremiah 38:7-13 • Hebrews 6:10
Blessed Is the Man Who Trusts in Yahweh	Jeremiah 39:18 • Jeremiah 17:7 • Psalm 37:39-40
Whoever Believes Will Not Be Put to Shame	Jeremiah 39:18 • Romans 10:11 • Ephesians 2:8-9
A Name Remembered When a Nation Is Not	Jeremiah 39:16 • Malachi 3:16-17 • Hebrews 11:39-40

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 39 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the fall of Jerusalem, Zedekiah's capture, and the oracle for Ebedmelech
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 39](#) - the 586 BC destruction placed in its chronology and covenant framework
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 39](#) - exposition of the dual prophecies about Zedekiah's eyes and their literal fulfillment

Jeremiah 39 - Opening Intro

After forty chapters of warning, the fall of Jerusalem gets eight verses and no adjectives.

That restraint is deliberate. There is no lament here, no theological summary, no "and thus was fulfilled." Just dates, names of Babylonian officers, the route the king took when he ran, and the order in which things burned. Jeremiah spent his life trying to prevent this; when it arrives he does not editorialize.

Two details are worth stopping on.

The first is Zedekiah's eyes. Jeremiah had prophesied that he would see the king of Babylon and speak with him mouth to mouth (chapter 34), while Ezekiel had prophesied that he would be brought to Babylon but would not see it (Ezekiel 12:13). Skeptics in the ancient world treated these as a contradiction. Verse 7 resolves them in the cruelest way available: he saw Nebuchadnezzar's face at Riblah, watched his sons die, and was blinded before the road to Babylon.

The second is verse 10. Nebuzaradan leaves "the poor of the people, who had nothing" in the land and gives them vineyards and fields. The people at the very bottom of Judah's social order - the ones with no property, no leverage, and no seat anywhere - end the chapter owning land for the first time in their lives. Nobody planned that. It is simply what happened when everything else was stripped away.

And then the chapter does something unexpected with its ending. It does not close on the ruins. It closes on Ebedmelech, and it makes a point of saying the word came to Jeremiah "while he was shut up in the court of the guard" - which means God arranged this man's rescue before the walls came down, while the prophet who would deliver it was still in custody.

The reason given is one line: "because you have put your trust in me." Not because he was Israelite - he was not. Not because he was ritually qualified - as a eunuch he was not. Because he trusted, and it showed up as courage on behalf of somebody else.

Before we read, hold that ordering. A nation with every advantage is rubble by verse 8. A foreign servant with no standing is named and preserved by verse 18. God keeps a different ledger than the one we keep.

Jeremiah 39:1-18 (WEB)

1 In the ninth year of Zedekiah king of Judah, in the tenth month, Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon and all his army came against Jerusalem, and besieged it.

2 In the eleventh year of Zedekiah, in the fourth month, the ninth day of the month, a breach was made in the city.²⁶

3 All the princes of the king of Babylon came in, and sat in the middle gate, Nergal Sharezer, Samgarnebo, Sarsechim, Rabsaris, Nergal Sharezer, Rabmag, with all the rest of the princes of the king of Babylon.

4 When Zedekiah the king of Judah and all the men of war saw them, then they fled, and went out of the city by night, by the way of the king's garden, through the gate between the two walls; and he went out toward the Arabah.²⁷

²⁶ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 25:3-4](#) • [Ezekiel 33:21](#) - the famine and the breach, and the day the fugitive reached the exiles with the news

²⁷ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 38:18](#) • [Amos 2:14-16](#) - exactly what he was warned of, and the swift finding no escape in that day

5 But the army of the Chaldeans pursued them, and overtook Zedekiah in the plains of Jericho. When they had taken him, they brought him up to Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon to Riblah in the land of Hamath; and he pronounced judgment on him.

6 Then the king of Babylon killed Zedekiah's sons in Riblah before his eyes. The king of Babylon also killed all the nobles of Judah.²⁸

7 Moreover he put out Zedekiah's eyes and bound him in fetters, to carry him to Babylon.²⁹

8 The Chaldeans burned the king's house, and the houses of the people, with fire, and broke down the walls of Jerusalem.³⁰

9 Then Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard carried away captive into Babylon the residue of the people who remained in the city, the deserters also who fell away to him, and the residue of the people who remained.

10 But Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard left of the poor of the people, who had nothing, in the land of Judah, and gave them vineyards and fields at the same time.^{31,32}

11 Now Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon commanded Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard concerning Jeremiah, saying,

12 "Take him, and take care of him. Do him no harm; but do to him even as he tells you."³³

13 So Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard sent, with Nebushazban, Rabsaris, and Nergal Sharezer, Rabmag, and all the chief officers of the king of Babylon;

14 they sent, and took Jeremiah out of the court of the guard, and committed him to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, that he should carry him home. So he lived among the people.³⁴

15 Now Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah, while he was shut up in the court of the guard, saying,

²⁸ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 34:3](#) • [Ezekiel 12:13](#) - he would see the king of Babylon's eyes, and he would not see Babylon - both came true

²⁹ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 25:7](#) • [Jeremiah 32:4](#) - the blinding recorded twice, and the word given while Jeremiah was under arrest

³⁰ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 7:14](#) • [Micah 3:12](#) - the house made like Shiloh, and Zion plowed as a field - a century of warning fulfilled

³¹ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 40:7](#) • [Matthew 5:5](#) - the poorest left in the land, and the meek who inherit the earth

³² Messianic Connection: [Luke 1:52-53](#) • [James 2:5](#) - the lowly exalted and the hungry filled, the poor of this world chosen to be rich in faith

³³ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 15:11](#) • [Proverbs 16:7](#) - the enemy made to entreat him, and a man's ways pleasing Yahweh so his enemies are at peace

³⁴ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 38:28](#) • [Jeremiah 26:24](#) - Ahikam's hand kept him alive once; now Ahikam's son takes him home

16 “Go, and speak to Ebedmelech the Ethiopian, saying, ‘Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: “Behold, I will bring my words on this city for evil, and not for good; and they will be accomplished before you in that day.”³⁵

17 But I will deliver you in that day,” says Yahweh; “and you will not be given into the hand of the men of whom you are afraid.

18 For I will surely save you, and you won’t fall by the sword, but you will escape with your life; because you have put your trust in me,” says Yahweh.’”^{36,37}

³⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 38:7-13](#) • [Hebrews 6:10](#) - God is not unjust to forget the work and love shown toward His people

³⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 17:7](#) • [Psalm 37:39-40](#) - blessed is the man who trusts in Yahweh - He delivers because they take refuge in Him

³⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [Romans 10:11](#) • [Ephesians 2:8-9](#) - whoever believes in Him will not be disappointed - by grace, through faith, not of works

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 37-39

- The danger of good news read wrongly - a reprieve mistaken for a rescue
- Self-deception named as the real enemy: "do not lift up your own souls"
- Curiosity about God's word that never becomes obedience to it
- A king with all the authority who will not use it, overruled by men he outranks
- The fear of being mocked as a sufficient cause for national catastrophe
- An outsider with no standing doing the one right thing nobody else would do
- Compassion measured in details - rags under the armpits before the ropes pull
- Truth spoken unchanged to the man who controls whether you eat
- Providence working through foreign hands: protection from the empire, not from the covenant people
- God keeping a different ledger - a nation in rubble, a servant named and preserved
- Trust as the stated reason for deliverance, in a man outside the covenant community

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who told Judah not to deceive themselves guard us from the stories we tell ourselves when the pressure lifts, and may we read our reprieves honestly.

May we never be people who ask Him for a word we have already decided not to obey.

May He give us the courage of the man who walked out to the gate and said plainly that what was done was evil, whatever it cost him afterward.

May we love people the way Ebedmelech did - not only pulling them out, but thinking about the rope burn.

May He deliver us from the fear of being mocked, and may no city of ours ever burn because we could not bear to look foolish.

May we speak the same word in the dungeon that we spoke in the street, and may our message not bend to whoever is holding the key.

And when everything we counted on is broken down and carried off, may we be found among those who trusted Him - remembered by name, and given our lives as a prize of war.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.